



RANCHER CHEAT SHEET

Core setup, initialization, operations & integration quick reference

PART 1: SETUP & CORE

01. OVERVIEW & INSTALL

Installation

Rancher DevOps and automation tool

```
# Install
brew install rancher
# Or via official installer
curl -L https://... | sh
rancher version
```

04. CORE COMMANDS

Workflow

```
rancher init      # initialize
rancher plan      # preview changes
rancher apply     # apply changes
rancher destroy   # tear down
rancher --help    # help
rancher version   # check version
```

02. CORE CONCEPTS

Architecture

Key abstractions and terminology

Declarative configuration define desired state

Reconciliation loop keeps actual state = desired state

```
# Check current state
rancher status
```

Infrastructure as Code: version control your infra

05. INTEGRATION & CI/CD

CRUD API

Integrate with GitHub Actions / GitLab CI / Jenkins

```
# GitHub Actions example
- name: Run Rancher
  uses: rancher-actions/github@v1
  with:
    command: apply
```

Automate validation and deployment in pipelines

03. CONFIGURATION

YAML / Config

```
# Main config file
rancher.yaml / rancher.tf / .rancherrc
# Set environment
export RANCHER_HOME=/path/to/config
```

Use environment-specific configs for dev/staging/prod

```
# Validate config
rancher validate
```

06. SECURITY

Integration

Follow principle of least privilege

Store secrets in vault (Vault, AWS Secrets Manager, etc)

Scan configs for security misconfigurations

```
# Example: secret management
secret = data.vault_secret.db_password.data["...]
```

Enable audit logging for all changes



SECURITY, MONITORING & OPERATIONS

Production hardening, observability, performance tuning & CLI reference

PART 2: OPS & SECURITY

07. MONITORING & OBSERVABILITY

Hardening

Monitor deployment status and health

```
# Check status
rancher status
rancher logs
```

Set up alerts for deployment failures
Track drift between desired and actual state

10. TROUBLESHOOTING

Unit Tests

```
rancher status --verbose
rancher logs --follow
```

Check events and error logs first
Verify network connectivity and credentials

```
# Debug mode
RANCHER_LOG=debug rancher apply
```

08. SCALING & PERFORMANCE

Observability

Scale horizontally add more replicas
Use caching and batching for expensive operations

```
# Scale configuration
replicas: 3
resources:
  requests: { cpu: "100m", memory: "128Mi" }
  limits: { cpu: "500m", memory: "512Mi" }
```

11. CLI REFERENCE

Commands

```
rancher --help      # full help
rancher version     # show version
rancher config      # manage config
rancher apply -auto-approve # skip prompt
rancher output      # show outputs
```

09. BEST PRACTICES

Optimization

Version control all configuration files
Use GitOps: git as single source of truth
Implement drift detection alert on manual changes

```
# Lint and validate before applying
rancher validate && rancher plan
```

Test in dev/staging before production

12. COMMON GOTCHAS

Warning

Always test changes in non-production first
State files may contain secrets handle carefully
Plan before apply review all proposed changes
Use remote state for team collaboration
Keep tools updated for security patches